

of tea for the day, Roop juggles multiple browser windows. He downloads his e-mail, which filter themselves into different folders—newsletters, personal, work and spam. He connects his PDA to his PC and gets updates from his favourite news channels using *avantgo.com* and sends off the e-mail he typed the previous night. “The PDA is a godsend for a person like me who’s frequently on the move. I can keep track of all my tasks for the day, track expenses and make a to do list on a device that can inconspicuously fit in my jacket pocket. All in all, I find this to be a very useful device, especially when I’m bored during the long commute everyday—I play games on it.”

Roop does most of his banking and bill payment from the office itself. “Net banking is such a lifesaver. I used to waste a lot of time paying bills and updating my passbook but now I can pay my bills, check my account or cheque status, transfer money or stop payment, without moving from this chair. I don’t know how I ever managed without it!”

MON 8-24
12:30 PM

His cell phone beeps. It’s a reminder for his meeting with the Vice President who’s at the head office in Delhi. Roop turns to his PC and starts the Video Conferencing linkup. This is the practice in his office when it



Karishma Shah
STUDENT

“There are two things on my wishlist: a scanner to digitise all my old photographs and a speedy broadband connection”

Campus capers

MON 8-24
10:45 AM

Mithibai college, Juhu

Supriya is hanging out with her classmates in the college canteen, when she remembers that she has a big test coming up. Pulling out her cellphone she punches an SMS to her batchmate Karishma Shah: ‘can i borrow ur psycho notes plz? thx bye’. The cellphone is a hand-me-down from her dad when he got himself a sleeker and smaller model. The family stays in touch through SMS all the time, be it a request for a special dish for dinner, or informing of a late night out.

Speaking of studies, “I get most of the research for my papers off the Net and then just photocopy them for a set of notes to exchange with friends. This way we all end up doing only a fraction of the research needed,” says Supriya. Fifteen minutes later, her friend Karishma joins in the discussion of how technology has changed lives, for better or for worse. Both agree that women are more inclined to use Internet for communication above anything else: “The most important way that technology has affected my life is communication; I get withdrawal symptoms if I’m away from my Net connection and my mobile phone. I feel cut off and lost without it,” says Karishma. She’s not much of a gadget freak and doesn’t have any gizmos on her wish list. “I got a CD-Writer so that I could burn audio CDs

and free up some space from my PC. I’d also like to buy a scanner because I have tonnes of photographs that I’d like to scan and upload to a photo album online, but that’s pretty much it.”

“I also plan to study further in the US or Canada and I’m studying for my GRE exams. I have joined an online training course that covers the GRE syllabus. It’s

Must-have Gadgets

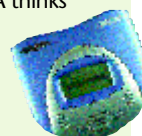
Cellphones: In the fast-paced, urban world, cellphones are a necessity. They are easy to carry around and have been getting smaller each year. Today’s cellphones offer advanced features such as text messaging, GPRS, games, calendar, calculator, reminder and custom ring tones.



PDA: A PDA used to be like a private secretary—you could schedule your daily work, make appointments and read text files. Today it can be equated with a personal computer—you can watch movies on it, play music, surf the Internet using a fully-featured Web browser and even use it as a handy-dandy digital camera!



MP3 Players: Digital music is here to stay, no matter what the RIAA thinks about it, and an MP3 player gives it the much-needed portability. MP3 players are more compact and portable than CD players and you can even buy one with Flash memory. Some provide up to 6 GB of music, which translates into a lot of albums (see ‘Music Unplugged’ on page 72).



Game Consoles: Consoles have always been the bigger brother to PC gaming, with higher market penetration and a larger roster of games. They are simple to use, addictive and can be played on a television. And there’s no issue of patches, driver updates, or system instability. If it’s no-frills gaming you’re after, a console is exactly what you need.



easier than ever to study this way and I always get access to the latest information,” asserts Karishma.

Home alone

MON 8-24
14:30 PM

Kumar Residence, Andheri

While the rest of the family is busy with the day’s work, Atul is playing *Counter-Strike* on the local area network. He has a few friends in the neighbourhood who are keen gamers and with very low ping times between their computers, the experience of overpowering



Vikram Mody
STUDENT

“I chat with my friends abroad, using a Web cam. It is so easy and saves me heaps of time and money”

comes to meetings with people from the head office or the regional offices. He had suggested this as an efficient and cost-effective method and now has some very pleased superiors.

He receives an SMS from his friend Ravi: ‘lunch @ 2?’ Roop punches ‘ok’ and sends it back immediately.